

PSAT 8/9

High-Yield 30

30 High-Yield Questions Weighted to the Real Digital PSAT 8/9 Blueprint

Reading & Writing • Math • Full Answer Explanations

Exclusive bonus for readers of the PSAT 8/9 Study Guide

Copyright

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How This Bonus Was Built

These 30 questions are not a random sample. They are weighted to approximate the real digital PSAT 8/9 section proportions: the official test splits its 98 questions 54 Reading & Writing to 44 Math, so this bonus mirrors that with 17 Reading & Writing questions and 13 Math questions.

Within Reading & Writing, the question types reflect the four official domains — Craft and Structure, Information and Ideas, Standard English Conventions, and Expression of Ideas. Within Math, the four official domains are covered too — Algebra, Advanced Math, Problem-Solving and Data Analysis, and Geometry and Trigonometry.

Every question below includes a full explanation: why the correct answer is right, and why each of the other choices is wrong. That second part is what most practice sets skip — and it's usually where the actual learning happens.

Reading and Writing

Question 1 | Craft and Structure — Words in Context

Passage: After weeks of practicing the same three chords, Malik finally felt ready to write his own song instead of just copying others. His confidence, once so _____, had grown steadily with every rehearsal.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. permanent
- B. widespread
- C. unnecessary
- D. fragile

Correct Answer: D

"Fragile" (choice D) fits because it contrasts with "grown steadily" — his confidence started weak/easily shaken and became stronger over time. "Permanent" (A) contradicts the idea that it changed. "Widespread" (B) and "unnecessary" (C) don't describe a personal quality that can "grow."

Question 2 | Craft and Structure — Words in Context

Passage: The new student was surprisingly _____ about joining the debate team, showing up early to every practice and volunteering to speak first.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. enthusiastic
- B. reluctant
- C. confused
- D. forgetful

Correct Answer: A

"Enthusiastic" (choice A) matches the evidence — showing up early and volunteering to speak first are signs of eagerness. "Reluctant" (B) is the opposite. "Confused" (C) and "forgetful" (D) don't match the described actions at all.

Question 3 | Craft and Structure — Text Structure and Purpose

Passage: A student council proposed adding a recycling bin to every classroom. Some teachers worried it would create more work. The council responded by sharing results from a nearby school where the same program cut classroom trash by half within two months.

Which choice best describes the function of the last sentence in the passage?

- A. It criticizes the teachers for resisting change.
- B. It provides evidence meant to ease the teachers' concern.
- C. It changes the subject to a different school issue.
- D. It repeats the teachers' worry in different words.

Correct Answer: B

The last sentence provides real data (cutting trash by half) that responds directly to teachers' worry about extra work — that's evidence addressing their concern (choice B). It doesn't criticize anyone (A), doesn't change topics (C), and doesn't just restate the worry (D) — it answers it.

Question 4 | Craft and Structure — Text Structure and Purpose

Passage: The article begins by describing one student's struggle to find a quiet place to study at home, then broadens to discuss the lack of study spaces across the whole school district, and ends by connecting the issue to a statewide funding debate.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the article?

- A. It compares two students who face opposite problems.
- B. It repeats the same example three times for emphasis.
- C. It moves from one student's experience to a wider district and state issue.
- D. It moves from a statewide issue down to one student's experience.

Correct Answer: C

The article explicitly widens from one student, to the district, to the state — specific to broad (choice C). Choice D reverses this order. Choices A and B describe structures (comparison, repetition) that don't match the description.

Question 5 | Information and Ideas — Central Ideas and Details

Passage: A 2024 survey asked 500 middle school students about their sleep habits. Students who reported going to bed after 11 p.m. were more likely to describe their mood as "irritable" the next day, though the pattern was weaker among students who took naps after school.

Which choice best states the main finding of the survey?

- A. Later bedtimes were associated with more irritability, though afternoon naps lessened the effect.
- B. Late bedtimes are always linked to bad moods, no matter what else a student does.
- C. Students who nap never report feeling irritable.
- D. The survey found no connection between sleep and mood.

Correct Answer: A

Choice A captures the whole finding: an association between late bedtime and irritability, plus the qualifier that naps weakened it. Choice B overstates with "always" and "no matter what." Choice C claims something absolute the passage never says. Choice D contradicts the reported association.

Question 6 | Information and Ideas — Central Ideas and Details

Passage: Community gardens take up a small fraction of total city land, yet a recent study found they produce a large share of the fresh vegetables grown within city limits. This makes them valuable to food access programs despite their modest size.

According to the passage, why are community gardens considered valuable to food access programs?

- A. Because they cover most of the city's available land.
- B. Because they are the only source of vegetables in the city.

- C. Because their small size makes them easy to maintain.
- D. Because they produce a large amount of food relative to their small size.

Correct Answer: D

The passage's key contrast is small land use vs. large vegetable output — that disproportion is why they're valuable (choice D). Choice A is factually wrong. Choice B overstates with "only." Choice C isn't discussed in the passage.

Question 7 | Information and Ideas — Command of Evidence

Passage: A teacher claims that students who review notes within a day of a lesson remember more than students who wait a week. In a class experiment, one group of 20 students reviewed notes the next day and averaged 85% on a later quiz, while another group of 20 waited a week and averaged 71%.

Which choice best supports the teacher's claim?

- A. Both groups had exactly 20 students.
- B. All students took the same quiz.
- C. The average score of the next-day group (85%) was higher than the week-later group's average (71%).
- D. The experiment involved a teacher and a class.

Correct Answer: C

The claim compares memory retention, so the relevant evidence is the score gap between groups — 85% vs. 71% directly supports it (choice C). Choices A, B, and D describe equal/neutral conditions that make the comparison fair but don't by themselves prove one method worked better.

Question 8 | Information and Ideas — Command of Evidence

Passage: A principal argues that a new morning announcement system reduced students being late to first period. Late arrivals dropped from 40 per day to 25 per day after the system started. During the same month, the school also moved the start of first period 10 minutes later.

Which choice best describes a weakness in using this data to support the principal's claim?

- A. The late-arrival numbers were not collected at the same school.
- B. A second change (the later start time) happened at the same time, so the drop can't be credited to the announcement system alone.
- C. The sample of students was too small to matter.
- D. Late arrivals actually increased after the system started.

Correct Answer: B

Because the later start time happened during the same month, the drop in late arrivals could be caused by either change — the data alone can't isolate the announcement system's effect (choice B). Choices A and D are factually wrong per the passage. Choice C isn't addressed by the passage at all.

Question 9 | Standard English Conventions

Passage: The classroom has a reading corner _____ students can pick a book during free time.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. where
- B. were
- C. we're
- D. where,

Correct Answer: A

"Where" (choice A) correctly introduces a clause describing the reading corner (a place). "Were" (B) and "we're" (C) are homophones that don't fit grammatically. Choice D adds an unnecessary comma separating the clause from what it describes.

Question 10 | Standard English Conventions

Passage: The set of science projects, submitted by four different classes this semester, _____ displayed in the school lobby.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. are
- B. were
- C. have been
- D. is

Correct Answer: D

The subject is "the set" (singular), not "projects" or "classes," which sit inside a modifying phrase. A singular subject takes "is" (choice D). The other choices agree with a plural noun instead of the true subject.

Question 11 | Standard English Conventions

Passage: By the end of the tournament, the two _____ trophies had already been engraved with their team names.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. winner's
- B. winners'
- C. winners's
- D. winners

Correct Answer: B

"Winners'" (choice B) is the correct plural possessive — there are two winning teams, so the apostrophe goes after the "s." Choice A is singular possessive. Choice C isn't a standard form. Choice D has no apostrophe, leaving "trophies" without an owner.

Question 12 | Standard English Conventions

Passage: Originally built as a train station, the city eventually converted the building into a public library.

Which choice best revises the sentence to correct a misplaced modifier?

- A. Originally built as a train station, a public library eventually came from the city converting the building.
- B. No change is needed.
- C. Originally built as a train station, the building was eventually converted by the city into a public library.
- D. The city, originally built as a train station, eventually converted the building into a public library.

Correct Answer: C

"Originally built as a train station" describes the building, not the city, so "the building" must follow the comma — only choice C does this. The original sentence (and choice D) wrongly implies the city was "originally built as a train station." Choice A still doesn't place "the building" right after the modifier.

Question 13 | Standard English Conventions

Passage: The school's spring concert, which many parents consider the highlight of the year _____ features every grade level performing together.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. ;
- B. .
- C. (no punctuation)
- D. ,

Correct Answer: D

"Which many parents consider the highlight of the year" is nonessential information inserted into the main sentence, so it needs a comma on both sides. Since it already opens with a comma, it must close with one too (choice D). Ending with a semicolon, period, or nothing (choices A, B, C) breaks the sentence's grammar.

Question 14 | Expression of Ideas — Transitions

Passage: The school play was performed two nights in a row. _____, both performances sold out within a day.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. Additionally
- B. However
- C. For example
- D. In contrast

Correct Answer: A

Both sentences describe positive facts about the same event, so "Additionally" (choice A) correctly adds a second positive fact. "However" (B) and "In contrast" (D) wrongly suggest a contradiction. "For example" (C) wrongly implies the second fact is an instance of the first.

Question 15 | Expression of Ideas — Transitions

Passage: Many students struggle to focus during long study sessions. Short breaks every 25 minutes, _____, can noticeably improve concentration.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. for instance
- B. therefore
- C. teachers report
- D. in other words

Correct Answer: C

"Teachers report" (choice C) works as a parenthetical attribution, making the sentence read naturally as a claim attributed to a source rather than a stated fact. "For instance" (A) and "in other words" (D) don't fit that slot. "Therefore" (B) would need an established cause, which the text doesn't provide.

Question 16 | Expression of Ideas — Rhetorical Synthesis

Passage: A student has researched two facts:

- A school's peer-tutoring program matched 60 students with tutors last year.
- The program relies entirely on student volunteers, with no paid staff.

The student wants to emphasize how the program achieved a large reach with minimal resources.

Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. The program matched 60 students last year, and it has no paid staff.
- B. Despite relying entirely on student volunteers, the program matched 60 students with tutors last year.
- C. The program matched students last year, and it uses volunteers.
- D. Last year was a good year for the program, which helped many students.

Correct Answer: B

Choice B directly connects the minimal resources (all-volunteer, no paid staff) to the large reach (60 students) with "despite" — exactly the emphasis wanted. Choice A lists both facts without that framing. Choice C omits the specific number. Choice D is vague and drops the volunteer detail.

Question 17 | Expression of Ideas — Rhetorical Synthesis

Passage: A student has researched two facts:

- A school garden club planted vegetables in 8 raised beds over two years.
- A survey found that students who visited the garden reported feeling calmer during the school day.

The student wants to present the connection between the garden club and students' sense of calm.

Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. The garden club planted vegetables in 8 raised beds over two years.
- B. A survey found that students reported feeling calmer during the school day.
- C. Garden clubs are a popular activity at many schools.
- D. After the garden club planted vegetables in 8 raised beds, students who visited reported feeling calmer during the school day.

Correct Answer: D

Choice D links both facts in one connected statement — the planting, then the resulting survey finding — exactly the connection wanted. Choices A and B each state only one fact alone. Choice C is a general claim not drawn from the notes.

Math

Question 18 | Algebra

If $3x + 4 = x + 14$, what is the value of x ?

- A. 3
- B. 7
- C. 5
- D. 9

Correct Answer: C

$3x + 4 = x + 14 \rightarrow 3x - x = 14 - 4 \rightarrow 2x = 10 \rightarrow x = 5$ (choice C). Choice A would come from a sign error; choices B and D don't satisfy the equation.

Question 19 | Algebra

The system of equations $x + y = 9$ and $x - y = 3$ has solution (x, y) . What is the value of x ?

- A. 6
- B. 3
- C. 4
- D. 7

Correct Answer: A

Adding the equations eliminates y : $(x + y) + (x - y) = 9 + 3 \rightarrow 2x = 12 \rightarrow x = 6$ (choice A). Choice B would be the value of y , not x ; choices C and D don't satisfy both equations.

Question 20 | Algebra

A school club charges \$3 to join plus \$2 for each event ticket. If Priya spent exactly \$15, how many event tickets did she buy?

- A. 4
- B. 5
- C. 7
- D. 6

Correct Answer: D

$3 + 2t = 15 \rightarrow 2t = 12 \rightarrow t = 6$ (choice D). Choices A and B don't use the full \$15 exactly; choice C would cost more than \$15.

Question 21 | Algebra

A parking lot charges \$5 for the first hour and \$1.50 for each additional hour. If Andre has at most \$11 to spend, what is the maximum number of whole hours he can park?

- A. 3

- B. 5
- C. 4
- D. 6

Correct Answer: B

The cost for h hours ($h \geq 1$) is $5 + 1.5(h - 1)$. Setting $5 + 1.5(h - 1) \leq 11$ gives $1.5(h - 1) \leq 6$, so $h - 1 \leq 4$ and $h \leq 5$ (choice B). At $h = 5$ the cost is exactly \$11; at $h = 6$ (choice D) it would be \$12.50, over budget.

Question 22 | Advanced Math

What are the solutions to $x^2 - x - 6 = 0$?

- A. $x = -2$ and $x = 3$
- B. $x = 2$ and $x = 3$
- C. $x = -3$ and $x = 2$
- D. $x = -2$ and $x = -3$

Correct Answer: A

$x^2 - x - 6$ factors as $(x - 3)(x + 2)$, since $-3 \times 2 = -6$ and $-3 + 2 = -1$. Setting each factor to zero gives $x = 3$ and $x = -2$ (choice A). The other choices come from sign errors made while factoring.

Question 23 | Advanced Math

The function $f(x) = 3x^2 - 2$. What is $f(3)$?

- A. 16
- B. 19
- C. 29
- D. 25

Correct Answer: D

$f(3) = 3(3)^2 - 2 = 3(9) - 2 = 27 - 2 = 25$ (choice D). Choice B would come from squaring after multiplying incorrectly; choices A and C come from other arithmetic slips.

Question 24 | Advanced Math

What is the value of $(2^3)(2^4)$?

- A. 14
- B. 4096
- C. 128
- D. 64

Correct Answer: C

When multiplying powers with the same base, add the exponents: $2^3 \times 2^4 = 2^{(3+4)} = 2^7 = 128$ (choice C). Choice A comes from adding the bases instead of the exponents; choice B comes from multiplying the exponents instead of adding; choice D is 2^6 , one power too few.

Question 25 | Problem-Solving and Data Analysis

A jacket's price was reduced from \$60 to \$48. By what percent was the price reduced?

- A. 12%
- B. 20%
- C. 15%
- D. 25%

Correct Answer: B

The dollar decrease is $\$60 - \$48 = \$12$. As a percent of the original price: $12/60 = 0.20 = 20\%$ (choice B). Choice A mistakes the dollar amount for the percent; choices C and D come from dividing by the wrong base.

Question 26 | Problem-Solving and Data Analysis

In a random sample of 150 students, 90 said they walk to school. Based on this sample, how many students out of a school of 600 would be expected to walk to school?

- A. 300
- B. 400
- C. 450
- D. 360

Correct Answer: D

The sample proportion is $90/150 = 3/5$. Applying that proportion to 600 students: $600 \times 3/5 = 360$ (choice D). Choice A would come from using $1/2$ instead of $3/5$; choices B and C come from other proportion errors.

Question 27 | Problem-Solving and Data Analysis

Five students scored 62, 78, 85, 70, and 90 on a project. What is the median score?

- A. 78
- B. 70
- C. 77
- D. 85

Correct Answer: A

Sorting the scores gives 62, 70, 78, 85, 90. With five values, the median is the middle (third) value: 78 (choice A). The other choices are close to the mean or other miscalculations, not the median.

Question 28 | Geometry and Trigonometry

A rectangle has a length of 11 and a width of 6. What is its area?

- A. 34
- B. 55
- C. 66

D. 17

Correct Answer: C

Area of a rectangle = length $\times$ width = $11 \times 6 = 66$ (choice C). Choice A resembles the perimeter ($2(11 + 6) = 34$), not the area. Choice B comes from a multiplication error. Choice D comes from subtracting instead of multiplying.

Question 29 | Geometry and Trigonometry

A circle has a radius of 6. What is its area, in terms of π ?

A. 6π

B. 36π

C. 72π

D. 12π

Correct Answer: B

Area = $\pi r^2 = \pi(6)^2 = 36\pi$ (choice B). Choice A confuses radius with area. Choice D doubles the radius instead of squaring it. Choice C doubles the correct answer.

Question 30 | Geometry and Trigonometry

A right triangle has legs of length 9 and 12. What is the length of its hypotenuse?

A. 15

B. 21

C. 13

D. 108

Correct Answer: A

By the Pythagorean theorem, $\text{hypotenuse}^2 = 9^2 + 12^2 = 81 + 144 = 225$, so the hypotenuse = $\sqrt{225} = 15$ (choice A). Choice B adds the legs instead of applying the theorem. Choice D is 9×12 , the area of a rectangle with those side lengths, not the hypotenuse.